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Overview: Deuteronomy

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Overview: Deuteronomy

Moses gives Israel final words of warning and blessing.

At the end of his life, Moses delivers a final call to covenant faithfulness. He covers the story so far, a collection of laws, and a charge for Israel to listen and obey rather than rebel. He sees Israel's dismal future as well as their promised hope.

Hear, O Israel

After 40 years of wilderness wandering, a new generation is ready to enter the promised land. Moses gathers them and delivers one final message.

He recounts Israel's rebellion and God's grace up to that point, and he calls them to covenant faithfulness. In this section we find the Shema (which Jesus later calls "the first and greatest commandment"). The heart of the Shema is a call to listen and obey by devoting your emotions and will to God alone. Moses then shares laws for Israel's worship and leaders as well as for their civil and social life.

At the conclusion of his speech, Moses gives a warning and ultimatum. To listen and obey God will lead to blessing, but to disobey will lead to devastation and exile. Moses knows the people well enough to know they will eventually choose rebellion. Yet even then, Moses looked forward to a future day when God would give Israel a new heart so they could fully love God and live.